
“Any man in favor of a **further prosecution** of this war is a fit subject for a **lunatic asylum**.”

NATHAN BEDFORD FORREST, SHORTLY BEFORE SURRENDERING HIS COMMAND, MAY 1865

It was said that General Robert E. Lee called Forrest the greatest soldier produced by the Civil War. To Union general Grant, he was “that devil,” while General Sherman thought he deserved killing even “if it costs 10,000 lives and breaks the Treasury.”

Devil on horseback

Wounded four times and having had 29 horses shot beneath him, Forrest was not easy to kill. One characteristic episode occurred in the aftermath of the Battle of Shiloh in April 1862. Encountering a force led by Sherman, Forrest galloped forward so recklessly that he left his escort behind and leaped unaccompanied into Sherman’s lines. Saber flashing, he tried cutting his way out, but was shot in the back. Apparently untroubled by the bullet lodged against his spine, Forrest swept up a Union soldier with one arm and planted him on his saddle to act as a shield. Then he rode back to safety. For Forrest, life had been, in his own words, “a battle from the start.” The son of a backwoods blacksmith who died when Forrest was 16, he grew up with barely six months of formal schooling. Nevertheless, he went on to achieve enormous wealth trading enslaved people, even buying Africans from the *Wanderer*, a notorious slave ship that brought an illegal cargo of kidnapped Africans to Jekyll Island, Georgia, in 1858, more than 50 years after the Atlantic trade had been abolished. He eventually attained the